CHAPTER 9

AN AMERICAN SHIP AT THE FRONTIERS OF THE SOLAR SYSTEM

… by the shore
Of Triton's Lake …
I will clear my breast of secrets.
—EURIPIDES, *ION* (CA. 413 B.C.)

Neptune was the final port of call in *Voyager 2*'s grand tour of the Solar System. Usually, it is thought of as the penultimate planet, with Pluto the outermost. But because of Pluto's stretched-out, elliptical orbit, Neptune has lately been the outermost planet, and will remain so until 1999. Typical temperatures in its upper clouds are about -240°C, because it is so far from the warming rays of the Sun. It would be colder still, except for the heat welling up from its interior. Neptune glides along the hem of interstellar night. It is so far away that, in its sky, the Sun appears as little more than an extremely bright star.

How far? So far away that it has yet to complete a single trip around the Sun, a Neptunian year, since its discovery in 1846.* It's so far away that it cannot be seen with the naked eye. It's so far away that it takes light—faster than which nothing can go—more than five hours to get from Neptune to Earth.